

Habitat & Cultivation Native to eastern parts of North America, wild indigo grows from North Carolina to southern Canada in dry, hilly woods.

Parts Used Root, leaves.

Constituents Wild indigo contains isoflavones, flavonoids, alkaloids, coumarins, and polysaccharides. The isoflavones are estrogenic, while the polysaccharides are immunostimulant.

History & Folklore Wild indigo was commonly used as a poultice by Native Americans and New World settlers to treat snake bite. The Mahicans used a decoction of the root to bathe cuts and wounds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Wild indigo is a strong antiseptic and immunostimulant, though at more than moderate doses it can produce nausea and vomiting. It is considered particularly effective for upper respiratory infections such as tonsillitis and pharyngitis, and is also valuable in treating infections of the chest, gastrointestinal tract, and skin. Its antimicrobial and immunostimulant properties combat lymphatic problems—when used with detoxifying herbs such as burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65), it helps to reduce enlarged lymph nodes. Wild indigo is frequently prescribed along with echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92) for chronic viral conditions or chronic fatigue syndrome. A decoction of the root soothes sore or infected nipples and infected skin conditions. When used as a gargle or mouthwash, the decoction treats canker sores, gum infections, and sore throats.

⚠ **Caution** Best taken on professional advice.

Benincasa hispida syn. *B. cerifa*
(Cucurbitaceae)

Wax Gourd, Petha

Description Hairy annual climber. Has 3-lobed leaves, tendrils, and large yellow flowers. Produces rounded fruit (gourds) about 16 in (40 cm) long.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to tropical Asia and Africa, this herb is cultivated in India and China as a vegetable. The fruit is harvested in late summer.

Parts Used Fruit rind, fruit, seeds.

Constituents Wax gourd contains saponins and guaridine.

History & Folklore

Wax gourd has been used as a food and medicine for thousands of years. It was first documented in the *Tang Materia Medica*, written in 659 CE.



Wax gourd

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese herbal medicine, a decoction of wax gourd seeds is used to “drain dampness” and “clear heat.” It is given for chest conditions and vaginal discharge. In combination with Chinese rhubarb (*Rheum palmatum*, p. 126), it is prescribed for intestinal abscesses. In Ayurvedic medicine, the seeds are used to treat coughs, fever, and excessive thirst, and to expel tapeworms. In an ancient Indian recipe, the fruit juice is mixed with lime juice (*Citrus aurantiifolia*) to prevent or stop bleeding.

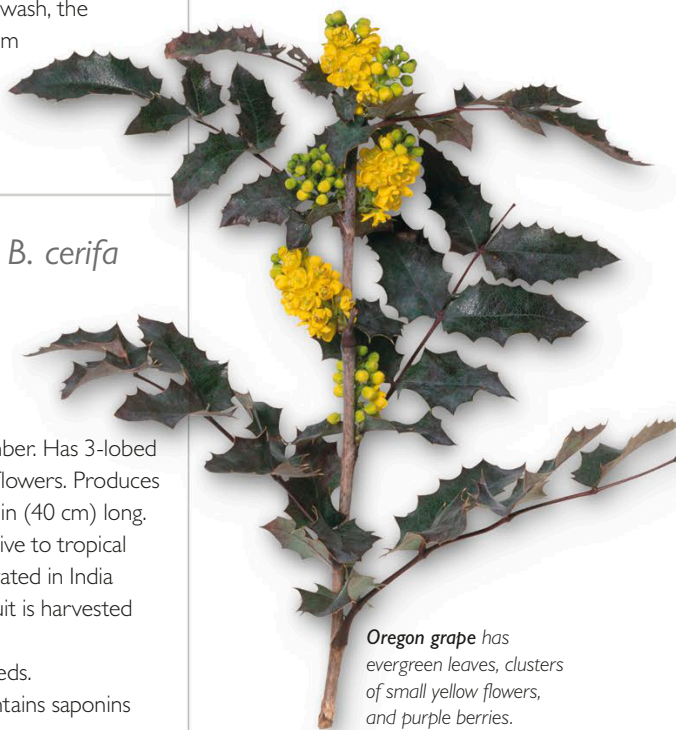
Research The fruit appears to have a cancer-fighting effect.

Berberis aquifolium, syn. *Mahonia aquifolium* (Berberidaceae)

Oregon Grape

Description Evergreen shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has shiny leaves, clusters of small yellowish-green flowers, and purple berries in autumn.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western North America, Oregon grape grows in the Rocky Mountains up to 6,600 ft (2,000 m), and in woods from Colorado to the Pacific coast. It is abundant in Oregon and northern California.



Oregon grape has evergreen leaves, clusters of small yellow flowers, and purple berries.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Oregon grape contains isoquinoline alkaloids (including berberine, berbamine, and hydrastine) and other alkaloids of aporphine-type. These alkaloids are strongly antibacterial and are thought to reduce the severity of psoriasis.

History & Folklore Californian Native peoples took a decoction or tincture of the bitter-tasting root for loss of appetite and debility. In the 19th and early 20th centuries, Oregon grape was an important herb in the Physiomedicalist movement, based on a combination of orthodox and Native American practices. In this context, it was prescribed as a detoxifier and tonic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Oregon grape is chiefly used for gastritis and general digestive weakness, to stimulate gallbladder function, and to reduce congestion problems (mainly of the gut). It also treats eczema, psoriasis, acne, boils, and herpes, and skin conditions linked to poor gallbladder function.

Research Clinical use of extracts of Oregon grape has been investigated in Germany, and there is now evidence that the root can be effective in relieving psoriasis. Extracts can be taken internally and applied locally on the skin. The alkaloid berberine is thought to prevent cell proliferation.

Related Species Barberry (*B. vulgaris*, see following entry) is similar to Oregon grape in its overall action, but it is generally stronger in the effect it produces.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Berberis vulgaris (Berberidaceae)

Barberry

Description Thorny deciduous shrub growing to 10 ft (3 m), with leathery leaves, yellow flowers, and red berries in autumn.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, barberry is naturalized in North America. It is cultivated as a garden plant and medicinal herb. The bark is gathered in spring or autumn, and the berries in autumn.

Parts Used Stem bark, root bark, berries.

Constituents Barberry contains isoquinoline alkaloids, including berberine and berbamine. Berberine is strongly antibacterial and amoebicidal, and stimulates bile secretion. Berbamine is strongly antibacterial. Many of the alkaloids are thought to be cancer-inhibiting.

History & Folklore In ancient Egypt, *Berberis* berries were macerated with fennel seed (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212) to make a drink for fevers. The berries are extremely sour but have been used in the past to make preserves—the French *confiture d'épine vinette* is one example.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Barberry acts on the gallbladder to improve bile flow and ameliorate conditions such as gallbladder pain, gallstones, and jaundice. Its strongly antiseptic property helps amoebic dysentery, cholera, and other similar gastrointestinal infections. The bark is